Chapter 3. The Major Genres

Developers, sellers, and players of video games classify them into genres so that they can easily describe what kind of gameplay a game offers without having to describe it in detail. Over the years, a number of standard game genres has evolved, although there are many more games that either don't fit into any of them or are hybrids of more than one genre. The classifications change from time to time as well, and some genres exist only on particular platforms. In this short chapter, we'll take a look at the major game genres, concentrating on the traditional ones from the PC and console game markets.

WHAT IS A GENRE?

In describing movies or books, the term *genre* refers to the content of the work. Historical fiction, romance fiction, spy fiction, and so on are different genres of popular fiction. With video games, however, *genre* refers to the types of challenges that a game offers. In games, the genres are independent of the content. Shooter games are one genre; they are set in the Old West, in a fantasy world, or in outer space, and they are still all shooter games.

> **GENRES** *are categories of games characterized by particular kinds of challenge, regardless of setting or game-world content.*

The earliest video and computer games usually ran on hardware so limited that they could offer only one kind of gameplay, and the genre boundaries were fairly strict. Arcade games such as *Asteroids* were pure action games, while computer games like *Super Star Trek* were pure strategy games. Many newer games blend elements of more than one genre. Sometimes they do this in a single gameplay mode. For example, *Deus Ex* combined both the resource management and character growth challenges of role-playing games (RPGs) with the action challenges of shooters, an unusual pairing at the time that it was released. Others implement more than one

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gameplay mode with different kinds of challenge in each. *Weird Worlds: Return to Infinite Space* provides a high-level turn-based mode that includes exploration and resource management challenges, and a low-level real-time combat mode with challenges that are all about tactics and timing.

It is increasingly difficult to classify games unequivocally into one genre or another, especially with smaller browser-based and mobile-phone games. The explosion of creativity that accompanied the arrival of these two platforms has meant that many games, such as *World of Goo* (**Figure 3.1**), don't belong clearly to one traditional genre. However, even the Google Play store for Android applications classifies games by genre.

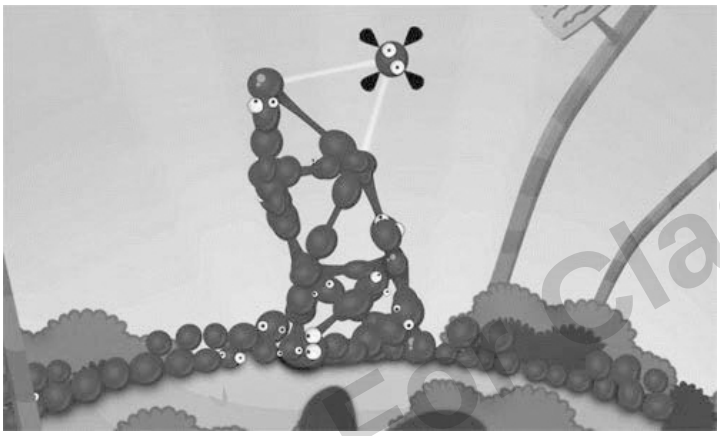

Figure 3.1 *World of Goo* combines construction, puzzle solving, and unusual physical mechanics.

Subgenres

Game genres are sometimes so general that it's useful to subdivide them into smaller groups, or *subgenres,* to better understand what the gameplay of a game will be like. First-person shooters, for example, come in many varieties: arena games, meant for high-speed multiplayer competition *(Team Fortress 2* is a good example); tactical shooters, in which stealth and ammunition management play large roles; open-world games such as the *Battlefield* series; and rail shooters that are set indoors and limit the player's movement to a largely linear path. Likewise, automobile-racing games can be grouped into those that offer combat between the cars and those that don't.

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These classifications change constantly according to the whims of developers, the gaming press, and of course the players themselves. As a designer who may be choosing a genre for your game, you should study the existing games that resemble the one you want to make and the things that people have said about it to get a better grasp of where your game will fall in the marketplace.

THE CLASSIC GAME GENRES

Here you'll find a brief introduction to the classic game genres, along with a screen shot that provides an illustrative example. If you want to learn more about a particular game genre, Peachpit Press offers a series of companion e-books, each entitled *Fundamentals of* <genre name> *Design,* that discusses how to design each one in detail.

Table 1.1 in Chapter 1, "Games and Video Games," listed types of challenges that games use to entertain people. Be sure you're familiar with it, because the following sections use its terminology.

Shooter Games

In *shooters,* the player takes action at a distance, using a ranged weapon. Therefore aiming is a key skill, particularly if the game provides limited ammunition. In a shooting game, the player must focus attention on two places at once: the area around the avatar, and the target or targets. Shooters can be subdivided into 2D shooters and 3D shooters, of which by far the most famous are the first-person shooters.

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2D Shooters

The action in 2D shooters takes place in an environment viewed from a top-down or side-view perspective (see **Figure 3.2**), or occasionally from a fixed first-person perspective in which the player faces oncoming or pop-up targets. Enemies shoot at the avatar, which can be a character or a vehicle, or approach to attack at close quarters. In many of these games, the player is under attack by overwhelming numbers of enemies and must shoot them as fast as possible; such games are often called *shoot-'em-ups*. The player is usually armed with one or more weapons, and some weapons may be better suited to particular enemies than others. It is rare for a 2D shooter to keep track of ammunition (except for particularly powerful types of weapons); instead, the player fires frenetically and indiscriminately. The weapons seldom damage anything except legitimate targets.

Figure 3.2 *Awesomenauts,* a multiplayer 2D shooter

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3D Shooters

3D shooting games, such as those in the *Halo* and *Crysis* series, have become so successful that to a great many younger gamers they are the epitome of the entire medium. 3D shooters are more realistic than 2D shooters, often presenting familiar, or at least recognizable, worlds (see **Figure 3.3**). In first-person shooters, the physics of the game is reasonably like that of the real world. Gravity works correctly (for the most part), sound diminishes with distance, objects cast shadows, and collisions are modeled with a fair level of accuracy.

Figure 3.3 *Crysis 3,* a 3D shooter with a particularly rich environment

3D shooters use either a first-person perspective (the *first-person shooter* or *FPS)* or a third-person perspective, and many now offer both. The first-person perspective is sometimes reserved for the view through a rifle's scope or sights and usually cannot be used while the avatar is moving.

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Action and Arcade Games

Action games include physical challenges. They may also incorporate puzzles, races, and a variety of conflict challenges, typically among a small number of characters. Action games often contain simple economic challenges as well, usually involving collecting objects. They seldom include strategic or conceptual challenges. Arcade games are action games designed around a business model of earning money through the player putting in coins. They are generally unwinnable, and simply get harder and harder until the player is certain to lose—though often they can put in more coins to continue play.

Action games may be further subdivided into a variety of subgenres. Two of the best known are *platform games* and *fighting games,* but these are far from the only ones.

Platform Games

Platform games, or *platformers,* are cartoonish games in which an avatar moves through a vertically exaggerated environment, jumping on and off platforms at different heights, while avoiding obstacles and battling enemies (see **Figure 3.4**). The avatar has a supernatural jumping ability and can't be harmed by falling long distances (unless he falls onto something dangerous or into a bottomless chasm, both common features of platform games). Most of the player's actions consist of jumping, augmented by special moves such as flip-moves or wall jumps, and by objects in the environment such as bouncy platforms and wind gusts. Platform games use unrealistic physics; usually the avatar can change directions in midair.

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Figure 3.4 *Spelunky,* a 2D platform game

Fighting Games

Fighting games have little in common with other action games because they do not involve exploration, shooting, or puzzle solving. They still qualify as action games because they place great demands on a player's physical skills: reaction time and timing. These games simulate hand-to-hand combat, usually using highly exaggerated moves modeled vaguely on Asian martial arts techniques (see **Figure 3.5**). (Serious boxing games belong more to the sports genre than to the action genre, because they try to model the techniques of boxing realistically.) Fighting games may be further subdivided into those in which characters fight in one-on-one bouts *(arena games)* and mêlée games in which one or two characters fight large numbers of opponents. (The latter are sometimes called *beat-'em-ups* or *brawlers.*) Fighting games also use hand-to-hand weapons such as swords and staves and a limited number of ranged weapons.

Figure 3.5 *Skullgirls,* a cartoonish fighting game

Strategy Games

Strategy games include strategic (naturally), tactical, and sometimes logistical challenges. They may also offer economic and exploration challenges to lengthen the game and give it more variety (see **Figure 3.6**). Once in a while, they also have a physical challenge thrown in for spice, but this often annoys strategically minded players.

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Figure 3.6 *Napoleon: Total War,* a real-time strategy game

Strategy games challenge the player to achieve victory through planning, and specifically through planning a series of actions taken against one or more opponents.

This definition distinguishes strategy games from puzzle games that call for planning in the absence of conflict, and from competitive construction and management simulations that require planning but not direct action against an opponent. Strategy games often include the reduction of enemy forces as a key goal, so most strategy games are war games in greater or lesser degrees of abstraction. Checkers (draughts), for example, is an abstract war game; Risk is slightly less abstract; and *Axis and Allies,* a board game about World War II, is fairly representational.

Strategy games fall into two main subgenres: classical turn-based games and real-time strategy games. Pure strategy games (those that contain only conflict challenges, with no economic or physical challenges) tend to be turn-based rather than operating in real time.

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Role-Playing Games

Role-playing games (RPGs) allow players to interact with a game world in a wider variety of ways than most other genres do and to play a richer role than many games allow. Most RPGs also offer an experience impossible in the real world: a sense of growing from an ordinary person into a superhero with amazing powers. Other genres usually provide players with these powers immediately, but in an RPG, the player earns them through successful play and gets to choose which particular abilities she wants to cultivate.

The essential parts of a computer role-playing game (CRPG) are the quest or story of the game (see **Figure 3.7**) and character growth. The quest usually requires some combat, and the rules of the game are designed to support it. The rules also define how character growth occurs. A successful CRPG depends on a captivating story and a rewarding character-growth path.

Figure 3.7 *The Elder Scrolls V: Skyrim,* seen from a first-person viewpoint

Most role-playing games involve tactical, logistical, and exploration challenges. They also include economic challenges such as collecting loot and trading it in for better weapons. They sometimes include puzzles and conceptual challenges. Older CRPGs never included action elements; they implemented combat via turn-based choices for the player to make. (*Puzzle Quest* still works this way.) Modern CRPGs have started to include physical challenges as part of their combat model, but these are seldom as difficult as in fighting games, for example.

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CRPGs have elements in common with many other genres; it is the way in which they implement them and the combinations in which they occur that set them apart. Because CRPGs include so many types of challenges, it's not unusual for people to make hybrids.

Sports Games

Sports games create a special challenge for the game designer. So many people play or watch sports that they come to a video game with high expectations about what the game will be like. A designer must learn to meet those expectations. Sports games are one of the most popular genres in all of video gaming, and a well-tuned game can turn into a highly enjoyable—and profitable—product line.

Unlike most other games, which take place in a world the player knows little about, sports games simulate a world the player knows a lot about: sporting events as they are in real life. No one has ever really led an army of elves into combat, and only a small number of people know how it feels to fly an F-16 fighter jet, but a great many people know what professional football looks like and how the game is played. Sports games encourage direct comparison with the real world (see **Figure 3.8**).

Figure 3.8 *Pro Evolution Soccer 2011*

Not all sports games are ultrarealistic, of course. Some, such as Electronic Arts' old Sega Genesis game *Mutant League Football,* are fantasy games even though they are based on real sports. Others, such as Midway's *NFL Blitz* football series, simplify a sport and deliberately make it more extreme for dramatic purposes. Skateboarding games often fall into this category as well.

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Most sports games concentrate on simulating actual matches, but many also include a number of management functions as well, such as the challenges of managing a team or an athlete's career. A few sports games implement only this aspect of the sport and don't allow the player to control individual athletes in matches. Occasionally called *manager games*, these are particularly popular in Europe.

Vehicle Simulations

Vehicle simulations create the feeling of driving or flying a vehicle, real or imaginary. In simulations of real vehicles, one of the chief goals is verisimilitude, an (apparently!) close relationship to reality (see **Figure 3.9**). You can expect your players to know a lot about these machines and to want an experience that is at least visually similar to that of really controlling one. If you're designing an imaginary vehicle, you're free to create any kind of driving experience that you like without being restricted by such things as gravity, g-forces, fuel capacity, and so on. Your game really needs just to create the feeling of movement; you can place whatever limitations you like on that movement.

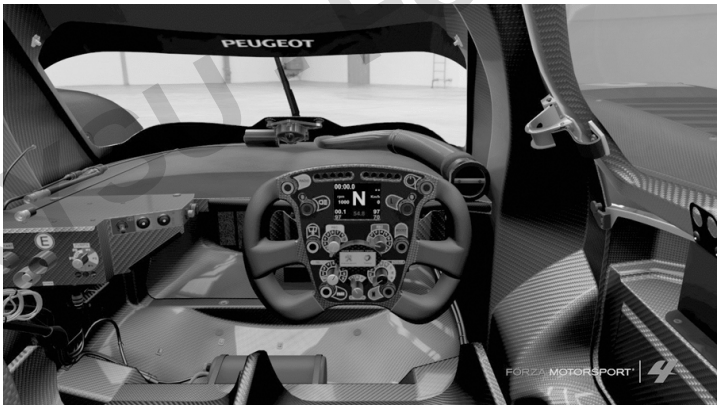

Figure 3.9 Cockpit view of *Forza Motorsport 4*

The biggest subgenres of vehicle simulations are flight simulators and driving simulators, although there are many more for boats and even trains. Flight simulators fall into two general categories: civilian and military. Driving simulators also tend to fall into two categories: organized racing and imaginary racing. Organized racing simulators try to reproduce the experience of

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driving a racing car or motorcycle in a real-world racing class, such as IndyCar. Some driving simulations implement combat between the cars, a further subgenre.

Construction and Simulation Games

Construction and simulation games, also called construction and management simulations (CMSs), offer players the chance to build things, such as anthills or cities, while operating within economic constraints (see **Figure 3.10**). These are games about processes. The player's goal is not to defeat an enemy but to create something within the context of an ongoing process. The better the player understands and controls the process, the more success she has at building. CMSs typically include both a free-form construction mode, in which the player can build things any way she likes, and prebuilt scenarios for her to manage. Most CMSs offer two sets of tools: one for building and one for managing. The actual process of building is usually an easy point-and-click mechanism, but managing can be tricky indeed.

Figure 3.10 *FarmVille,* a hugely successful browser-based CMS with an isometric camera model

These games primarily offer economic and conceptual challenges. Only rarely do they involve conflict or exploration, and they almost never include physical challenges.

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Adventure Games

Adventure games are quite different from most other games on the market. An adventure game isn't a competition or a simulation. An adventure game doesn't offer a process to manage or an opponent to defeat through strategy and tactics. Instead, an adventure game is an interactive story about a character whom the player controls (see **Figure 3.11**). This character is the player's avatar, but he's more than merely a representative of the player. He is a fictional person in his own right, a protagonist, the hero of the story. Although both adventure games and role-playing games possess this quality, RPGs normally offer a heavily numbers-based character-growth system (levels, weapons, skills, and so on), while adventure games do not—their character growth is dramatic, not numeric.

Figure 3.11 *Heavy Rain*

As the designer of an adventure game, it's your job to bring not just a story but a world to life—a world in which a story is taking place. Your talents at creating places, characters, plots, dialogue, and puzzles will be tested as in no other genre. Adventure games chiefly provide exploration and puzzle solving. Sometimes they contain conceptual challenges as well. Pure adventure games may include physical challenges, but only rarely.

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Puzzle Games

In puzzle games, puzzle solving is the primary activity, though puzzles may occur within a story line or lead up to some larger goal. That doesn't mean that you can offer a random collection of puzzles and call it a game; puzzle games usually provide a series of related challenges, variations on a theme. The types of puzzles offered include recognizing patterns, making logical deductions, or understanding a process. In most cases, the puzzles give the player clues that have to be unraveled or solved somehow to meet the victory condition. Physics-based puzzle games like *Angry Birds* or *Cut the Rope* (**Figure 3.12**) are exceptions; they generally have to be solved by trial and error. A hidden-object game also qualifies as a sort of puzzle game, although its challenge is purely to look closely at a complicated scene.

Figure 3.12 *Cut the Rope: Time Travel*

The number of puzzle games on the market has exploded since about 2000, when web- and smartphone-

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based gaming began to take off. They are a large part of the casual market and need not be really challenging to be fun and successful. For example, *Bejeweled* requires the player to match three jewels to remove them from a grid but contains so large an element of chance as new jewels appear that it requires very little brainwork. Puzzle games offer logic challenges and conceptual challenges almost exclusively, although occasionally they include time pressure or an action element. They often also offer multiple solutions.

SUMMARY

You now know the major genres and subgenres used by the game industry. These are not all that exist, only the best-known and best-selling examples. Genres are not meant to constrain your imagination, but they provide a framework for design, a sort of scaffold upon which to build your game without inventing everything from scratch—which lowers some of the risk in designing a new game. Designing a game within a well-known genre also helps you to explain your game concisely to funding agencies, retailers, and players. Chapter 4, "Understanding Your Player," discusses players and their attitudes to games in more detail.

DESIGN PRACTICE EXERCISES

1. Genre classifications vary considerably. Try looking at those from MobyGames (www.mobygames.com/browse/games), Yahoo! Games (http://games.yahoo.com), and the Android or iOS app stores for mobile phones. Which genres are present or absent in the different locations? What accounts for the differences?
2. Which genres do you like, which are you indifferent to, and which do you actively dislike? What differentiates them? Do you feel this says something about you as a player? Talk to someone else you know who has different tastes and think about what might make their preferences different from yours.

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DESIGN PRACTICE QUESTIONS

Choosing a genre for your game (or deciding that it does not belong in any genre) is part of defining your game's concept, a process that Chapter 7, "Game Concepts," discusses in detail. When you're thinking about it, consider the following questions:

1. Do the challenges and actions that you want to offer your player suggest that it belongs in a particular genre? Are there certain actions that the player will probably be performing most of the time, such as driving, that would tend to put it in a certain genre?
2. If you sell your game via either a game store or an online shop or portal, there is a good chance that that organization will want to categorize your game in a genre. Try looking at different outlets such as Yahoo! Games or the Apple App Store to see where you think your game would go.
3. Try describing your game to someone you think is a potential player, *without* naming any particular genre. Ask them which genre they think it belongs to. Do you agree?

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